

General English

Grammar, Vocabulary and Communication

Topics Covered:

- Parts of Speech
- Sentence Structure
- Punctuation
- Vocabulary Building
- Reading Comprehension
- Writing Skills
- Grammar Rules
- Essay Writing
- Common Mistakes and How to Fix Them

Chapter 1: Parts of Speech

Every word in the English language belongs to one of eight parts of speech. Understanding these is the foundation of good grammar.

The Eight Parts of Speech

1. **Noun** – Names a person, place, thing, or idea. (dog, London, happiness)
2. **Pronoun** – Replaces a noun to avoid repetition. (he, she, it, they)
3. **Verb** – Expresses action or state of being. (run, is, seem, create)
4. **Adjective** – Describes or modifies a noun. (blue, enormous, clever)
5. **Adverb** – Modifies a verb, adjective, or another adverb. (quickly, very, often)
6. **Preposition** – Shows relationship between a noun and other words. (in, on, under, beside)
7. **Conjunction** – Joins words, phrases, or clauses. (and, but, because, although)
8. **Interjection** – Expresses emotion. (Oh! Wow! Ouch!)

Tip: A single word can function as different parts of speech. 'Fast' can be an adjective ('a fast car') or an adverb ('he runs fast').

Chapter 2: Sentence Structure

A sentence is a group of words that expresses a complete thought. It must contain at minimum a subject and a predicate (verb).

Types of Sentences by Purpose

- **Declarative** – States a fact or opinion. Ends with a full stop.
- **Interrogative** – Asks a question. Ends with a question mark.
- **Imperative** – Gives a command or request.
- **Exclamatory** – Expresses strong emotion. Ends with an exclamation mark.

Types of Sentences by Structure

- **Simple** – One independent clause: 'The dog barked.'
- **Compound** – Two independent clauses joined by a conjunction: 'The dog barked, and the cat ran away.'
- **Complex** – One independent + one dependent clause: 'Although it was raining, we went for a walk.'
- **Compound-Complex** – Two independent clauses + one or more dependent clauses.

Clauses and Phrases

A **clause** contains a subject and a verb. An **independent clause** can stand alone as a sentence. A **dependent clause** cannot. A **phrase** is a group of words without both a subject and a verb.

Chapter 3: Punctuation

Punctuation marks are the traffic signals of writing — they tell the reader when to pause, stop, or change direction.

Key Punctuation Marks

- **Full Stop (.)** – Ends a declarative or imperative sentence.
- **Comma (,)** – Separates items in a list, clauses, or introductory phrases.
- **Semicolon (;)** – Links two closely related independent clauses.
- **Colon (:)** – Introduces a list, explanation, or quotation.
- **Apostrophe (')** – Shows possession (Sarah's) or marks a contraction (don't).
- **Quotation Marks** – Enclose direct speech or titles.
- **Question Mark (?)** – Ends a direct question.
- **Exclamation Mark (!)** – Indicates strong feeling or emphasis.
- **Hyphen (-)** – Joins compound words or word parts.
- **Dash (—)** – Sets off parenthetical information or a dramatic pause.

Classic comma error: 'Let's eat, Grandma!' vs. 'Let's eat Grandma!' — a comma can save a life.

Chapter 4: Vocabulary Building

A rich vocabulary allows you to express ideas precisely, understand complex texts, and communicate with confidence. Vocabulary growth is a lifelong process.

Strategies for Building Vocabulary

- **Read widely** – Novels, newspapers, essays, and academic texts expose you to new words in context.
- **Use context clues** – Infer the meaning of unknown words from surrounding text.
- **Learn word roots** – Latin and Greek roots unlock hundreds of words. E.g., 'port' (carry): import, export, portable.
- **Study prefixes and suffixes** – 'un-', 're-', '-tion', '-ful' change word meaning systematically.
- **Use new words** – Writing and speaking new vocabulary cements retention.

Synonyms, Antonyms, and Homonyms

- **Synonyms** – Words with similar meanings (happy / joyful / content).
- **Antonyms** – Words with opposite meanings (hot / cold, brave / cowardly).
- **Homonyms** – Words that sound the same but differ in meaning (to / two / too; there / their / they're).

Formal vs Informal Register

Formal English is used in academic writing, business, and professional settings. Informal English is appropriate in casual conversation. Choosing the right register is a key communication skill.

Chapter 5: Reading Comprehension

Reading comprehension is the ability to understand, interpret, and evaluate what you read. It is central to success in all academic subjects.

Levels of Comprehension

- **Literal** – Understanding what is directly stated in the text.
- **Inferential** – Reading between the lines; understanding implied meaning.
- **Evaluative** – Making judgements about the text's purpose, bias, or quality.

Active Reading Strategies

- **Preview** – Scan headings and topic sentences before reading in full.
- **Annotate** – Underline key ideas, circle unfamiliar words, write margin notes.
- **Summarise** – After each paragraph, state the main idea in one sentence.
- **Question** – Ask who, what, when, where, why, and how as you read.
- **Visualise** – Create a mental picture of descriptions and processes.

Identifying the Main Idea

The main idea is the central point an author wants to convey. It is often in the topic sentence (usually the first sentence of a paragraph). Supporting details expand on the main idea through examples, evidence, or explanation.

Chapter 6: Writing Skills

Effective writing is clear, organised, and suited to its purpose and audience. Strong writing is built through planning, drafting, and revision.

The Writing Process

1. **Pre-writing** – Brainstorm ideas, create a mind map or outline.
2. **Drafting** – Write freely, focusing on getting ideas down.
3. **Revising** – Review content, structure, and clarity.
4. **Editing** – Correct grammar, spelling, punctuation, and style.
5. **Publishing** – Present the final version to your audience.

Types of Writing

- **Narrative** – Tells a story with characters, setting, plot, and theme.
- **Descriptive** – Creates a vivid picture using sensory detail.
- **Expository** – Informs or explains using facts and evidence.
- **Persuasive/Argumentative** – Convinces the reader to adopt a viewpoint.

Paragraph Structure

Topic sentence – Introduces the main idea of the paragraph.

Supporting sentences – Provide evidence, examples, and explanation.

Concluding sentence – Summarises or links to the next paragraph.

Chapter 7: Grammar Rules

Grammar is the system of rules governing sentence structure. Correct grammar ensures writing is clear and credible.

Subject-Verb Agreement

A verb must agree with its subject in number. A singular subject takes a singular verb; a plural subject takes a plural verb.

- Correct: 'The dog **barks**.' Incorrect: 'The dog **bark**.'
- Correct: 'The children **play**.' Incorrect: 'The children **plays**.'

Tense Consistency

Use the same tense throughout a piece of writing unless there is a clear reason to change. Mixing past and present tenses randomly confuses the reader.

Active vs Passive Voice

- **Active voice** – Subject performs the action: 'The chef cooked the meal.' (Clear and direct)
- **Passive voice** – Subject receives the action: 'The meal was cooked by the chef.' (Often wordier)

Active voice is generally preferred in formal and academic writing for clarity and conciseness.

Pronouns and Antecedents

A pronoun must clearly refer to a specific noun (its antecedent) and agree in gender and number. Ambiguous pronoun reference is a common writing error.

Chapter 8: Essay Writing

An essay is a structured piece of writing that develops and supports a central argument or idea. The standard structure is the foundation of academic writing.

The Five-Paragraph Essay Structure

- 1. Introduction** – Opens with a hook, provides background context, and ends with a clear thesis statement.
- 2. Body Paragraph 1** – First main point with evidence and explanation.
- 3. Body Paragraph 2** – Second main point with evidence and explanation.
- 4. Body Paragraph 3** – Third main point with evidence and explanation.
- 5. Conclusion** – Restates thesis, summarises main points, ends with a final thought.

The Thesis Statement

The thesis is the most important sentence in an essay. It states the writer's main argument and previews supporting points. A strong thesis is specific, arguable, and focused.

Weak thesis: 'Social media is bad for people.'

Strong thesis: 'Excessive social media use negatively affects adolescents' mental health by reducing face-to-face interaction, disrupting sleep patterns, and promoting unrealistic self-comparison.'

Linking Words and Transitions

Transitions guide the reader through your argument. Useful examples: Furthermore, However, In contrast, As a result, In conclusion, For example, Nevertheless, Therefore, Consequently, In addition.

Chapter 9: Common Mistakes and How to Fix Them

Even experienced writers make mistakes. Recognising and correcting common errors is the mark of a thoughtful, self-editing writer.

Common Grammar and Style Errors

Mistake	Incorrect	Correct
Its vs It's	The dog wagged it's tail.	The dog wagged its tail.
Your vs You're	Your going to love this.	You're going to love this.
There/Their/They're	Their going over there house.	They're going to their house.
Double negatives	I don't have no money.	I don't have any money.
Dangling modifier	Running fast, the bus was missed.	Running fast, she missed the bus.
Run-on sentence	I like cats they are cute.	I like cats because they are cute.
Comma splice	It rained, we stayed home.	It rained, so we stayed home.

Proofreading Tips

- Read your writing aloud — your ear catches errors your eye misses.
- Read backwards sentence by sentence to focus on each sentence in isolation.
- Leave time between writing and editing; fresh eyes spot more mistakes.
- Check one type of error at a time (first grammar, then spelling, then punctuation).

Summary: Mastery of English grammar, vocabulary, and writing skills opens doors in education, careers, and everyday communication. Consistent reading and deliberate practice are the most powerful tools for improvement.